

Refuse and reject

Teaching guide

Decline an action or turn down an offer.

Understand the distinction

Refuse can take to + verb: I refused to sign. It can also take an offer or request: refuse an invitation. Reject commonly takes a noun naming something not accepted: reject a proposal, reject an application.

Do not use reject to do for declining an action. Either verb can sound strong depending on context. Decline is often a courteous choice for an invitation. State a reason or an alternative when it helps the conversation, without inventing one.

Compare the patterns

ACTION

She refused to sign the form.

Refuse takes a to-infinitive.

PROPOSAL

They rejected the proposal.

Reject takes the proposal as its object.

INVITATION

Thank you, but I must decline.

A courteous way to turn down an invitation.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: He refused ___ answer.

2. Correct this: They rejected to meet us.

3. Can refuse take a noun?

Use it in your own life

Decline an invitation politely without adding a false reason.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. to

Use refuse to do something.

2. They refused to meet us.

Reject does not take this to-infinitive pattern.

3. Yes: refuse an invitation or refuse help.

Its patterns are broader than refuse to do.

One possible response

Thank you for inviting me, but I cannot join you this time.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-41.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Decline an invitation politely without adding a false reason.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.